كتاب كليلة ودمنة

Kalīlah and Dimnah

How Anūsharwān Sent Barzawayh to India to Transcribe *Kalīlah and Dimnah*

God, who is blessed and exalted, created His creatures through His mercy, and in His beneficence gave them strength to serve Him. He provided them with the means to live prosperous lives in this world and to save themselves from punishment in the next. The most excellent gift that God bestowed is the intellect. It is the faculty appropriate to all things. Only by means of the intellect can a dweller in this world who aspires to the hereafter—by striving here to save his soul from the terrors of what comes next—live a prosperous life, increase his merit, and perform deeds that are appropriate for both worlds. Only by means of the intellect can those who strive to do good act effectively and be safe from fear of punishment in the afterlife; for the intellect is the means to every good and the key to every desire—none can dispense with it. 1.1

Acquired through experience, the intellect is a faculty hidden within a person, like fire latent in wood; the nature of fire is in the wood, but it only emerges by rubbing: it remains invisible until it is struck by something else, whereupon it ignites and burns. Similarly, the nature of the intellect is latent in a person: it is made manifest through education, and strengthened by experience. When it is strong, it is best at managing experiences and tempering behavior. It secures every benefit and repels every evil. Nothing, then, is better or more excellent for a person than the intellect, when it is supported by education and strengthened by experience. Someone who is endowed by his Creator with intellect and who bolsters himself by diligently pursuing education will enjoy good fortune and fulfill his hopes in this world; and in the next world he will attain the most excellent lot, procure the greatest reward, and reach the most exalted station. What is more, intellect bolsters the state, upholds the realm, and ennobles the king. Only through it and under its guidance do both kings and commoners prosper. 1.2

God has bestowed on our fortunate king, Anūsharwān, the most excellent intellect and amplest fortune. He has also blessed him with a fine 1.3

education, a thirst for knowledge, an extensive knowledge of philosophy, an inquisitiveness about the unknown, and a keenness for the truth of things. In these he has attained what no king before him ever has. During his quest for learning, he heard about a book by India's philosophers, one so prized by that country's kings and scholars that it was kept under guard in their royal libraries. This book was the foundation of all education, the pinnacle of every science, the guide to every benefit, and the key to salvation in the hereafter. It supported and aided kings in all the ways they needed in order to properly administer their realms, and it educated the common people in the ways to please their king and to improve their lives. This work was *The Book of Kalīlah and Dimnah*.

1.4 When the king got confirmation of what he had heard about this book and its usefulness in educating and fortifying the intellect, he could not rest until he had acquired it and examined it. Being a man of intelligence and education, he also asked the people of his kingdom to search the realm for a learned man, intelligent, educated, literate in both Persian and Sanskrit, eager for knowledge, devoted to perfecting his education, and diligent in examining and explicating works of philosophy. Such a man was brought to the king: a handsome youth, highly accomplished, and perfect in intellect and education. He was a renowned physician, proficient in Persian and Sanskrit. His name was Barzawayh the son of Azdahar.[1]

1.5 When Barzawayh came before the king, he prostrated, then stood with head bowed. "Barzawayh," said the king, "I have selected you because I have been told of your superior learning and intellect, your fine education, and your eagerness to pursue knowledge wherever it may be found, and because I have received word about a particular book in India."

The king then told him the story, reported what he had heard about the book, and expressed a strong desire to obtain a copy. "Prepare to travel, for I am sending you to India. Use your intelligence and astuteness to extract the book from their libraries and get it away from their scholars, jurists, and sages. Transcribe it into Persian in its entirety, for your benefit and for ours, as there is no copy of this book in any of our libraries or anywhere in the kingdom.[2] Take as much money as you wish. If it runs out, send word and I will supply you with more. Hurry, and spare no effort in your pursuit of knowledge. Whatever the expense, everything in our treasury is at your disposal to cover your expenses in the pursuit of knowledge."

The king commanded the astrologers to draw up a horoscope and select a day of departure, an auspicious hour, and a precise time. Barzawayh took twenty-five saddlebags of money with him, each containing ten thousand dinars.[3]

Barzawayh departed with the money and traveled quickly, day and night. **1.6** Once he reached India and had settled, he acquainted himself with the court and mingled in gatherings of nobles and commoners. He inquired about the king's favorites and assistants, and about the scholars and philosophers. He began paying his respects by visiting them in their homes, and would inquire about the court. He told them that he was a stranger who had come to their land to pursue knowledge and education, and that he needed their assistance in his quest. He asked for their guidance and prayers, but carefully concealed the goal of his journey, hiding any mention of it, and only alluding to it indirectly. Thus he continued for a long time, leading the scholars to believe that he was sharpening skills he already possessed and furthering his knowledge of subjects he already knew, but all the while he was surreptitiously inquiring about the object of his quest.

In the course of his long stay, he made many Indian friends—nobles, com- **1.7** moners, scholars, and masters of every trade. He made one friend his confidant and adviser, on account of his refinement, exceptional learning, and superior understanding. He sought his advice and felt at ease with him in every circumstance, and kept only the object of his quest concealed from him. He subtly probed and tested him, to determine whether he should be the one to whom he entrusted his secret during his stay there. He continued to examine his character and eventually came to trust him, realizing that he was indeed the right person to entrust with his secret, and that he would shoulder the burden of his request and assist him diligently in what he sought. So he treated him with more and more kindness. Given the length of his stay, by the time he hoped to achieve his purpose, he had incurred considerable expenses, entertaining people, and dining and drinking with them, in order to learn who was trustworthy and able to assist him in his objective. Of all his acquaintances, he felt at ease only with this one friend.

After Barzawayh had sufficiently appraised his friend's intellect to trust him, he said to him one day when they were alone, "My friend, I don't want to hide from you any more than I already have, or keep you in the dark about me. I want you to know that I've come to India for a purpose, and it isn't what it appears to be. I know that a man of intelligence needs only certain signs—a look, a gesture—to know the secrets of another man's mind and his innermost thoughts."[4] 1.8

"None of this was hidden from me," said the Indian, "even though I haven't broached the subject of why you're here and what it is you're after, or mentioned that you're concealing the real object of your search by pretending it's something else. I wanted to treat you as a brother, so I was reluctant to confront you with my sense that you were hiding something. Now your secret designs are clear. Since you have spoken first, I will tell you about yourself, your secret mission, and why you've come. You've come to our country to rob us of our priceless knowledge and prized treasures, and take them back to your country to satisfy your king. Your presence here is a deception, and your friendliness trickery. But when I saw your patience throughout your stay, your dogged pursuit of your goal, and your care not to utter a single word that might hint at your secret, my admiration for your intellect grew, and I wanted to become your friend. Never have I seen anyone of more refinement, of greater resolve in pursuit of a goal, better able to keep something secret, or of finer character, especially in a foreign land among people whose nature and disposition are unfamiliar to you. 1.9

"A man's intelligence reveals itself in eight ways—first, in his kindness and graciousness; second, in knowing his soul's inclinations and safeguarding his tongue; third, in his obedience to kings and endeavoring to please them; fourth, in knowing to whom he can confide a secret and how to go about revealing it to a friend; fifth, in decorous comportment, elegant behavior, and sweet speech at court; sixth, in keeping his own secrets and those of others; seventh, in controlling his tongue and not saying anything without careful consideration and deliberation; and eighth, in answering at gatherings only what he has been asked and revealing nothing he will regret. Anyone who unites these qualities will attract good fortune and profit, and avoid misfortune and loss, and they all are clearly discernible in you and apparent to me. 1.10

God keep you and enable me to enjoy your friendship! Anyone in whom these eight qualities are found deserves assistance in his quest and in reaching his objective. But what you are seeking frightens me and fills me with anxiety and trepidation. We beseech God to keep us safe."

1.11 Barzawayh felt confident about accomplishing his mission when he discovered that the Indian had answered him gently, without rebuke or chiding, even though the Indian had realized that Barzawayh's friendship with him was motivated by deception and cunning in pursuit of his objective and saw him as someone intent on plunder and theft. Barzawayh replied, "It turns out that I won't need to rely on the many types of learning in which I am proficient, the premises I've established, the ramifications I've detected, the branches and details I've devised—you've already divined a great deal about my intentions and discerned much on the basis of the slightest evidence. By your God-given intellect and discernment, you've spared me the trouble of arguing. I have received a response in a few words that apparently you will assist me in my mission. When a scholar learns a secret, when it is confided to a person of intelligence and discretion, he stands firm and fulfills all the hopes of the confider of the secret, as strong as a castle with a stone foundation, as a palm tree with deep roots, or as a mountain that winds cannot unsettle or shake."

1.12 "Nothing is better than love," responded the Indian. "Whoever has love in his mind deserves to have a friend who shares his mind with him and doesn't hold back his thoughts. Good conduct begins with the keeping of secrets; when a secret is shared by two, it makes its way to three, and when it does, it becomes such common knowledge that its keeper will be unable to disavow it, like clouds when they are scattered—no one doubts that they are scattered, and anyone saying so will be believed by everyone who sees that they are. For my part, I am exceedingly happy and delighted with your friendship and company. What you seek, however, cannot remain concealed; it will inevitably leak out wherever people assemble, and when it becomes public, my life will be in such peril that no ransom, however great, could save it. Our king is harsh and severe. He punishes the slightest offense. Imagine what he will do in a case like this!"

Barzawayh replied, "Scholars have praised the friend who keeps a friend's secret. I rely on you in the matter that has brought me here. I've revealed it to you, and hope it will succeed because of you. It is serious business and I know the danger is great, but I trust your acumen, discretion, caution, and resourcefulness in devising a way for me to realize my hopes through your efforts and with your good fortune and blessing, even if you are troubled by fear. I know you aren't afraid that I'll tell anyone about it; you fear that your compatriots who surround the king might discover the secret. But I don't expect it to be leaked, since I am leaving and you are staying. For as long as I am here, there will be no third party; and when I leave, you need have no fear that you will reveal it to your own detriment." **1.13**

At these words, the Indian granted his request and gave him the books he wanted. Barzawayh went to work interpreting and copying them. The task took so long that his provisions and expenses mounted. He wore himself out, staying up at night and working all day, fearing all the while for his life. When he was satisfied with the job he had done with the book, and with other books besides, he wrote to Anūsharwān that despite fatigue and fear he had completed the book he had been sent to get, along with other books of Indian science that he knew the king would need, and would convey to the king everything he had acquired. **1.14**

Anūsharwān rejoiced when he read the letter and knew that Barzawayh had indeed accomplished his mission. Fearing, however, that fortune might intervene and frustrate his joy by depriving him of what Barzawayh had obtained, he immediately ordered a letter to be written commanding Barzawayh to come home without delay. He wrote that Barzawayh could expect to be handsomely rewarded as a result of the king's renewed esteem; that as the king's favorite he would be appointed vizier. The king dispatched the letter with a trusted courier. He ordered him not to take the main highway, lest he be intercepted and the secret be divulged, in which case all his efforts would come to naught. **1.15**

When the messenger reached Barzawayh, he delivered the letter in secret. Barzawayh read it, packed his bags, and left immediately for Anūsharwān's court. As soon as Anūsharwān learned of his arrival, he ordered that he be brought into his presence. When he saw how pale, fatigued, and exhausted **1.16**

Barzawayh was, he took pity and said, "Rejoice, faithful servant; you shall soon taste the sweet fruit of your devotion. Be glad, for you have earned the gratitude of the entire nation as well as a great reward from us." He commanded Barzawayh to rest mind and body for seven days, and then return, which Barzawayh did.

1.17 On the eighth day, the king summoned Barzawayh and commanded all the high officials and nobles to attend. When they had all assembled, the king commanded that the books Barzawayh had brought from India be fetched. The books were opened and their contents read before the audience. When they heard the contents—the learning, culture, intelligence, and marvels the Indians had recounted via the tongues of animals and birds—they rejoiced and thanked God for what He had bestowed on them through Barzawayh. They invoked God's blessing on him and showered him with praise for his painstaking efforts to acquire the books and bring them.

1.18 The king commanded that the storerooms of jewels, gold, silver, and garments be opened, and entreated Barzawayh to take whatever he wished. Barzawayh prostrated himself before the king, invoked God's blessing on him, and said, "May God in His generosity grant the king honor in this world and the next, and reward him with the greatest reward. By the king's approval, God has freed me of need for the goods of this world by means of what He has bestowed on me at your hands, O great, generous, and fortunate king. I have no need for wealth. Nevertheless, because complying with the king's wishes and doing what pleases him gives me joy, I will take a garment of Qūhistān weave to wear while serving the king and at court."

1.19 Barzawayh agreed to take the garment home, if only to impress the royal family and the courtiers. He then said, "May God prosper the king and grant him honor! When a person of intelligence and cultivation is honored, given gifts, and treated with favor, it behooves him to be thankful, no matter how much he may deserve it. In gratitude to the king, I pray that God will grant him lasting joy and happiness in all things. But I have one wish—may God increase the king's might—which, to my mind, is the greatest, most perfect, and loftiest thing I could hope for after the king's approval. If the king sees fit, it will be easy for him to grant my request, but it will be something of great value and importance to me."

"Ask and you shall be given whatever you desire," said Anūsharwān. 1.20
"Plead and your plea will be granted most generously, for we deem you worthy of a great reward. Even if you ask to be made co-ruler, we will not deny your request—let alone anything else. Speak! Everything you ask will be given freely and generously."

"May God honor the king and reward him well on my behalf," said Bar- 1.21
zawayh. "I cannot reproach the king for my fatigue and trouble; on the contrary, he deserves my thanks for having compensated me and for allowing me to share in this benefit. The king's generosity and good opinion are the best compensation. May he then magnify his favor toward his servant and perfect his favor to him and to his family by commanding and enjoining Buzurgmihr the son of Bukhtigān to employ his talents to compose a chapter about my life and character. Let Buzurgmihr deploy his choicest language, his most elegant words, and his best style. May the king command that this chapter, when completed, be placed with the book's other chapters, to keep the memory of me alive as long as I am in the world and after my death. Should the king do this, he will have honored me and my family for as long as this book continues to circulate and be read in this world."

When the king, along with his scholars and officials, heard Barzawayh's 1.22
words, they were pleased by his reasoning, high-mindedness, and desire for enduring honor in this world. "Gladly and with pleasure!" replied the king. "Your request deserves to be granted. It may seem momentous to you, yet how small it is compared to what you deserve!"

The king immediately sent for Buzurgmihr and said to him,[5] "Buzurg- 1.23
mihr, you know Barzawayh's devotion to us: how he strove to please us, exposed himself to perils and dangers for our benefit, and wearied himself to make us happy. You know the favor he has done us and the knowledge and wisdom we have gained through him. You know that we offered him wealth and gifts from our treasuries, but he accepted none of this. What he desires of us and for himself is something very small, something he sees as a reward and an honor." The king then explained Barzawayh's request. "I want you to assist me in this matter, for I request it and it will bring me joy. I want you to exert yourself, however difficult it may be, and to write a chapter to

go with the other chapters of the book, one that mentions Barzawayh's virtues, his early life, his distinguished lineage, his profession, his education, and his eminence, including how we sent him to India on our mission; the boons he brought back for us, for which we have honored and distinguished him; and the state he was in upon his return from India. Use the most laudatory language you can find. Spare no effort, so that you bring joy to Barzawayh, to me, and to the entire kingdom. It will bring joy to you, in particular, because of your love of learning and of scholars. You will be the most fortunate of people, for whenever the book is read and Barzawayh is mentioned, you will share in Barzawayh's fame and acclaim. Make it the first chapter of the book. Let me know when you have finished it and placed it where it belongs, so I can assemble the most important people in the kingdom and you can read it to them. In this way, the full extent of your judiciousness, learning, and effort to please us will become visible to them."

When Buzurgmihr heard the king's words and the great importance he attached to the project, he bowed low and said, "Your Majesty, may God make your joy, gladness, and happiness endure! May He grant you in this world honor exceeding that of all creatures, and in the hereafter the best of dwellings with the righteous who merit the Gardens of Bliss." **1.24**

Buzurgmihr left the king's presence and began composing the chapter the king had commanded. He described Barzawayh's life from the time his father sent him to be educated[6] until the time the king sent him to India, and he returned with the book. In this chapter, he described as best he could what he knew about Barzawayh's education and way of life, his manifest contempt for the world, his asceticism, his desire for the hereafter, and what his soul longed for in its ultimate destination. He omitted nothing concerning Barzawayh's character and profession, all in his best style and manner of composition. Then he informed the king that he had completed the chapter and had placed it at the beginning of the book. **1.25**

The king assembled high officials, nobles, and common folk. He summoned Buzurgmihr to bring the book and—in Barzawayh's presence—commanded that it be read aloud to the people. Buzurgmihr stood up, opened the book, and read "The Chapter of Barzawayh" to the people. The king and all the people rejoiced at Buzurgmihr's intelligence and learning, **1.26**

and at the effort he had expended to praise Barzawayh without engaging in fabrication or specious claims. The king and all the nobles commended him, thanked him, and praised him in the highest terms. The king bestowed a splendid reward of money, jewels, and clothing, but Buzurgmihr accepted only one garment. He donned it to impress his colleagues, as it was a garment such as the king himself might wear. Barzawayh thanked him, kissed his head and hand, and then turned to the king and said, "Your Majesty, may God make your honor and beauty endure, for you have honored me by what you have commanded Buzurgmihr to write in this book."

Here ends the Account of How Anūsharwān Sent
Barzawayh to India and What Happened to Him.